

Veterans Backbone

Safeguarding Principles

Purpose

Safeguarding sits at the heart of everything Veterans Backbone does.

Its purpose is to protect people from harm, respond appropriately to risk, preserve dignity and autonomy, and ensure that safety is prioritised whenever concerns arise.

Safeguarding is not a box-ticking exercise. It is an ongoing responsibility shared by everyone involved with Veterans Backbone.

Where there is a risk of harm, safeguarding takes precedence over all other considerations.

Scope

These principles apply to:

- All participants
 - Staff
 - Volunteers
 - Trustees
 - Contractors
 - External professionals working with or alongside Veterans Backbone
 - All activities, programmes, buildings, land, and environments operated by Veterans Backbone
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Our Safeguarding Principles

Veterans Backbone operates on the following safeguarding principles:

Adults Have The Right To Make Their Own Choices

We recognise that adults have the right to make informed decisions about their own lives, even where those decisions may carry risk.

Safeguarding is not about removing autonomy. It is about ensuring people have the information, support, and opportunity to make safe and informed choices.

Vulnerability Is Not A Permanent Label

People may become vulnerable because of circumstances, trauma, health, crisis, isolation, or significant life events.

Vulnerability can be temporary, situational, or fluctuating.

We do not define people by their worst day.

Safeguarding Is Proactive

We believe concerns should be raised early.

Waiting until a situation becomes a crisis helps nobody.

Creating safe environments, clear boundaries, and supportive relationships reduces risk before harm occurs.

Safeguarding Is Human-Led

Safeguarding decisions are always made by people.

Policies, frameworks, systems, and technology may support decision-making, but responsibility remains with named individuals.

Accountability cannot be delegated.

Safety Overrides Convenience

Where a genuine safeguarding risk exists, action will be taken.

This may include sharing information, involving external agencies, restricting access, or implementing protective measures.

Protecting people always comes before avoiding uncomfortable conversations.

What Safeguarding Means

Safeguarding includes protecting people from:

- Abuse
- Neglect
- Exploitation
- Coercion
- Harm to self
- Harm to others
- Unsafe environments
- Unsafe practices
- Serious deterioration in wellbeing where risk is present

Safeguarding does not require somebody to be formally classified as vulnerable before support or intervention can occur.

Shared Responsibility

Everyone involved with Veterans Backbone has a responsibility to:

- Remain alert to safeguarding concerns
- Act when something feels unsafe
- Raise concerns appropriately
- Support a culture of safety, respect, and accountability

Ignoring concerns is not an acceptable option.

Confidentiality And Safety

Privacy and confidentiality are respected wherever possible.

However, confidentiality is not absolute.

Where there is a risk of harm, information may be shared with appropriate individuals or agencies in order to protect safety and wellbeing.

Information sharing will always be proportionate, lawful, and necessary.

Working With External Agencies

Where safeguarding concerns require escalation, Veterans Backbone may work with:

- Emergency services
- Police
- Local authority safeguarding teams
- Healthcare professionals
- Other relevant statutory or regulatory bodies

We cooperate fully with lawful safeguarding investigations.

Boundaries And Conduct

Safeguarding is strengthened by:

- Clear professional boundaries
- Respectful conduct
- Transparent decision-making
- Appropriate accountability
- Safe and supportive environments

Boundary violations are treated seriously and may be considered safeguarding concerns.

Training And Awareness

Safeguarding awareness forms part of the culture of Veterans Backbone.

Staff, volunteers, and relevant stakeholders are expected to understand their safeguarding responsibilities and act accordingly.

Final Principle

Safeguarding is not about control.

It is about protecting people, preserving dignity, reducing harm, and creating environments where individuals can recover, rebuild, and move forward safely.

At Veterans Backbone, safeguarding is everybody's responsibility.